

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Higher Education and Research English



Conversation lab

8 complete workplace dialogues, followed by eight additional role-play cases. Study the exchanges, then make the conversation your own.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For faculty, postdoctoral researchers, graduate students, lab managers, research administrators, grant staff, ethics-board coordinators, and academic program leaders.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Inside this conversation lab

Original fictional training conversations in professional English. These are realistic scripts, not transcripts of actual people. The professional roles are the speaker labels; all figures, incidents, and organizations are invented.

01 Study design discussion

02 Grant specific aims

03 A result that did not reproduce

04 Protocol amendment

05 Authorship discussion

06 Responding to peer review

07 Reproducible analysis handoff

08 Conference questions

Then try eight independent role-play cases, followed by feedback criteria and references.

Read it. Hear it. Make it yours.

1. Read the setting. Identify the roles, the immediate problem, and what each speaker needs.
2. Read the whole conversation aloud with a partner. In a group, give a third person the observer role. For three-speaker scripts, assign each professional a separate voice.
3. Notice how the speakers ask a specific question, qualify a claim, disagree, explain a technical point, or agree on a next step. Underline language you would actually use.
4. Cover the script. Recreate the exchange using the situation and professional roles. Keep the meaning, but change the wording.
5. Switch roles and introduce a complication: a missing record, a different priority, an unavailable colleague, or a changed assumption. End with a clear outcome or unresolved question.

Register and terminology

These colleagues use concise professional language. In an internal technical meeting, familiar abbreviations can be natural. With a new colleague or a client, expand unfamiliar terms and check understanding. Keep disagreement directed at the evidence or proposal, and match the degree of certainty to what is known.

Independent study

Speak each role aloud. Pause before the reply and supply your own response before revealing the next line. Record a second version using invented details, then compare its clarity and tone with the script.

Professional context

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

FULL DIALOGUE 01 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Study design discussion

Researchers refine an overly broad question.

Roles: Principal investigator / Postdoctoral researcher

Principal investigator: Our question asks whether the program improves wellbeing. Which outcome and population do we mean?

Postdoctoral researcher: We should specify the target group, measurement instrument, and follow-up period.

Principal investigator: The available dataset may not cover the full period.

Postdoctoral researcher: Then either revise the feasible question or obtain suitable data; don't imply the design answers more than it can.

Principal investigator: I'll map the variables and missingness before we finalize the protocol.

Postdoctoral researcher: I'll review the design assumptions and proposed analysis with the team.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Our question asks whether the program improves wellbeing. Which outcome and population do we mean?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: name one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 02 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Grant specific aims

A researcher and grants officer review a proposal.

Roles: Research lead / Grants officer

Research lead: Aim two depends entirely on a technique we haven't established. Is that too risky?

Grants officer: Reviewers need to understand the feasibility evidence and what happens if that method fails.

Research lead: We have pilot data, but only under one condition.

Grants officer: State that accurately and explain the alternative approach and decision points.

Research lead: I'll revise the milestones and connect the budget to the actual work.

Grants officer: I'll check the funder's requirements and the consistency of the aims, timeline, and resources.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Aim two depends entirely on a technique we haven't established. Is that too risky?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: name one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 03 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

A result that did not reproduce

A lab discusses conflicting experimental runs.

Roles: Graduate researcher / Lab manager

Graduate researcher: The second run didn't reproduce the first result. Should I leave it out of the presentation until we know why?

Lab manager: Include it with the conditions and controls. The discrepancy is part of the evidence.

Graduate researcher: The reagent lot and incubation time differ between runs.

Lab manager: Record those differences without assuming either caused the result.

Graduate researcher: I'll show both datasets and propose the comparisons needed to investigate.

Lab manager: Preserve the raw files and agree on the next experiment before repeating the work.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "The second run didn't reproduce the first result. Should I leave it out of the presentation until we know why?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: name one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 04 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Protocol amendment

A researcher proposes changing participant recruitment.

Roles: Research coordinator / Ethics coordinator

Research coordinator: Recruitment is slow. Could we broaden eligibility before the next session?

Ethics coordinator: Check whether the change requires prior ethics approval under the applicable process.

Research coordinator: We haven't amended the approved protocol yet.

Ethics coordinator: Then prepare the proposed change and its implications for consent, risk, and analysis for review.

Research coordinator: I'll keep recruitment within the approved criteria while that is assessed.

Ethics coordinator: I'll confirm the review route and communicate the decision once it is issued.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Recruitment is slow. Could we broaden eligibility before the next session?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: name one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 05 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Authorship discussion

Collaborators clarify credit before submitting a paper.

Roles: Corresponding author / Collaborating researcher

Corresponding author: We haven't agreed on authorship order or contribution statements. Can we settle that before submission?

Collaborating researcher: Yes. Let's review actual contributions against the relevant journal and institutional criteria.

Corresponding author: One colleague provided resources but hasn't reviewed the manuscript.

Collaborating researcher: We should discuss their contribution and the requirements with them, rather than assume a position.

Corresponding author: I'll circulate a proposed contribution record for everyone's review.

Collaborating researcher: Make room for corrections and resolve disagreements before asking the team to approve submission.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "We haven't agreed on authorship order or contribution statements. Can we settle that before submission?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: name one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 06 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Responding to peer review

Two authors plan a response to a critical reviewer.

Roles: Lead author / Coauthor

Lead author: The reviewer asks for a causal claim we can't support with this design.

Coauthor: Explain the limitation respectfully and revise any wording that overstates the result.

Lead author: We can add a sensitivity analysis, but it won't turn the study into an experiment.

Coauthor: Say what that analysis addresses and what it doesn't.

Lead author: I'll quote the relevant comment and give a point-by-point response with manuscript locations.

Coauthor: I'll check that each claimed revision is actually present in the new version.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "The reviewer asks for a causal claim we can't support with this design." What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: name one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 07 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Reproducible analysis handoff

A researcher transfers an analysis to a colleague.

Roles: Data analyst / Research associate

Data analyst: The notebook runs on my laptop, but it relies on files in my downloads folder.

Research associate: We need documented inputs, environment details, and a reproducible project structure.

Data analyst: Some source data have sharing restrictions.

Research associate: Keep those restrictions intact. Document how authorized users obtain the data and include permissible test data where appropriate.

Data analyst: I'll record package versions and the exact analysis steps.

Research associate: I'll attempt a clean run and report any missing dependencies or unclear transformations.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "The notebook runs on my laptop, but it relies on files in my downloads folder." What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: name one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 08 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Conference questions

A researcher practices a conference discussion with a colleague.

Roles: Presenter / Faculty colleague

Presenter: If someone asks whether the result generalizes, how should I frame the answer?

Faculty colleague: Start with the population and conditions actually studied, then describe what remains untested.

Presenter: I could say the mechanism is plausible elsewhere but hasn't been demonstrated by this study.

Faculty colleague: Yes, if the evidence supports that distinction. Don't turn plausibility into a finding.

Presenter: I'll prepare a slide showing the sample and main limitations.

Faculty colleague: And invite a question about the next study rather than promise an outcome you haven't investigated.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "If someone asks whether the result generalizes, how should I frame the answer?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: name one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

Eight more situations to make your own

The following cases are open role plays. They give you facts, contrasting roles, useful expressions, and a short model response. Use what you learned from the complete dialogues to create a longer exchange.

Preparation: two minutes. Conversation: three to five minutes. Feedback: one minute. Switch roles and repeat with the second-round challenge.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 01

Research Questions and Study Design

SHARED CASE

A research proposal asks whether a program "works" without specifying the outcome or population.

Role A | Responding professional

Clarify missing information before responding. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Useful expressions

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Cover this until after your first attempt

What outcome would count as improvement, for whom, and over what period? A clearer research question will help us choose an appropriate design and describe its limits.

Second round

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 02

Grant Proposals and Specific Aims

SHARED CASE

A grant draft promises to solve a broad scientific problem using a small pilot study.

Role A | Responding professional

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Useful expressions

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Cover this until after your first attempt

The pilot can test feasibility and provide preliminary evidence. It cannot resolve the entire problem. I'll narrow the aim so the proposed work and the claim match.

Second round

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 03

Lab Meetings and Data Challenges

SHARED CASE

A result differs from an earlier experiment, but the lab notes omit a protocol change.

Role A | Responding professional

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

Useful expressions

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

Cover this until after your first attempt

Could we compare the protocol versions and recorded conditions? Please add the missing change to the record so the team can assess possible explanations for the difference.

Second round

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 04

Research Ethics and Human Subjects

SHARED CASE

A researcher wants to reuse participant data for a new question. The existing approval and consent materials have not been reviewed.

Role A | Responding professional

Clarify missing information before responding. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Useful expressions

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Cover this until after your first attempt

Does the proposed use fall within the relevant approval and consent arrangements? Let's check with the appropriate ethics and data-governance processes before assuming reuse is permitted.

Second round

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 05

Authorship, Collaboration, and Credit

SHARED CASE

Collaborators disagree about authorship late in a project. Their contributions and expectations have not been discussed together.

Role A | Responding professional

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You hold a relevant concern that has not been discussed. Raise it when invited and ask who will decide. Help the facilitator state one unresolved question accurately.

Useful expressions

Let's hear ... before we decide.

The point we still need to resolve is

Who will make this decision, and what do they need?

Cover this until after your first attempt

Could we document each contribution and review the applicable authorship criteria as a group? That will give us a clearer basis for the discussion than relying on assumptions about rank or effort.

Second round

A participant interrupts or the meeting is running out of time. Protect a turn to speak and close with an accurate decision record.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 06

Peer Review and Revision Responses

SHARED CASE

A reviewer points out that a manuscript's claim goes beyond its sample. The authors agree that the wording needs revision.

Role A | Responding professional

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You are frustrated because an earlier message created an expectation. Explain that expectation. Ask your partner to distinguish the correction from anything still uncertain.

Useful expressions

My earlier message did not make ... clear.

I'm sorry for The correct information is

Let me check that the revised explanation addresses

Cover this until after your first attempt

Thank you for identifying this limitation. We have narrowed the claim to the studied sample and added a discussion of generalizability. The response should point the reviewer to the revised passage.

Second round

The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 07

Data Management and Reproducibility

SHARED CASE

A shared dataset has variable names but no description of units, missing values, or collection dates.

Role A | Responding professional

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

Useful expressions

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know ...

Cover this until after your first attempt

Could you add a data dictionary covering units, missing-value codes, and collection dates? Those details will help another researcher interpret and reuse the data correctly.

Second round

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 08

Academic Presentations and Conferences

SHARED CASE

An audience member asks whether a small study proves a general theory. The presenter needs a concise answer.

Role A | Responding professional

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Useful expressions

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Cover this until after your first attempt

The study offers evidence relevant to the theory under these conditions. It does not establish the theory in every setting. A useful next step would test whether the finding holds in a broader sample.

Second round

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

Lesson conversations and speaking practice

The following sections match 05 and 06 on the industry webpage and in the learner workbook. Each lesson has three ten-turn conversations and two bounded speaking scenarios. These are original fictional teaching scripts, not transcripts of real people.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

What does works mean in this proposal?

Fictional study-design meeting using the lesson case: a proposal asks whether a program works but does not identify an outcome or population.

01 • Research supervisor: The research question asks whether the program works. Which outcome and population do you mean?

02 • Graduate researcher: I was thinking about first-year students, but I haven't specified what improvement we would measure.

03 • Research supervisor: Then first-year students is a proposed population, not a complete study definition yet.

04 • Graduate researcher: Could we focus on completion of the introductory course rather than the broad phrase student success?

05 • Research supervisor: That is more specific. We still need to clarify the course, observation period, and comparison.

06 • Graduate researcher: Should I write a directional hypothesis before those choices have been agreed by the team?

07 • Research supervisor: You can propose one, but its methodology and limitations depend on the question we actually define.

08 • Graduate researcher: I'll bring a bounded question about course completion and mark the comparison and time period as unresolved.

09 • Research supervisor: Good. Avoid promising a causal answer before the design supports that interpretation.

10 • Graduate researcher: I'll clarify the question first so the method follows the intended outcome rather than a vague claim.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Compare experiences or estimate an effect?

Fictional research planning: a team proposes interviews about a mentoring program, while a sponsor expects a numerical estimate of its causal effect.

01 • Research coordinator: Our plan proposes interviews, but the sponsor expects a numerical estimate of the mentoring program's effect.

02 • Principal investigator: We need to clarify the research question. Exploring experiences differs from estimating a causal effect.

03 • Research coordinator: Could interviews explain what participants found useful without establishing how much the program changed outcomes?

04 • Principal investigator: Yes. That is a different contribution, with its own methodology and limitations.

05 • Research coordinator: Then we shouldn't present the interview plan as already answering the sponsor's quantitative expectation.

06 • Principal investigator: Correct. Ask which decision the sponsor needs to inform and what evidence would be relevant.

07 • Research coordinator: I'll explain the proposed qualitative focus and identify the effect estimate as outside the current design.

08 • Principal investigator: Please avoid saying one approach is universally better. The question determines which methods are appropriate.

09 • Research coordinator: Can we discuss alternative scope before committing recruitment or a hypothesis the current design cannot test?

10 • Principal investigator: Absolutely. Let's agree the bounded research question and then review the necessary design and approvals.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

The population is broader than the available sample

Fictional proposal discussion: a researcher can recruit from one evening seminar but has written a question about all university students.

01 • Research supervisor: Your question concerns all university students, but recruitment is limited to one evening seminar. How do those align?

02 • Graduate researcher: They don't align fully. The available sample is narrower than the population named in the proposal.

03 • Research supervisor: Could you clarify whether the study is exploratory within that seminar or intended to estimate a broader pattern?

04 • Graduate researcher: An exploratory study within the seminar is more realistic with the access currently available.

05 • Research supervisor: Then state that boundary and consider how seminar participation may limit what the findings represent.

06 • Graduate researcher: Should I assume evening students have particular work habits to explain the limitation?

07 • Research supervisor: No. You can identify the recruitment boundary without inventing characteristics that haven't been measured.

08 • Graduate researcher: I'll narrow the research question and keep broader applicability as an open issue, not a promised outcome.

09 • Research supervisor: Good. We can review whether the methodology answers that narrower question before discussing wider claims.

10 • Graduate researcher: I'll bring the revised population, proposed outcome, and remaining design questions to our next meeting.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Research Questions and Study Design

A research proposal asks whether a program "works" without specifying the outcome or population.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Second round: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for scenario 1: What outcome would count as improvement, for whom, and over what period? A clearer research question will help us choose an appropriate design and describe its limits.

Scenario 2 | A six-month outcome with a two-week study

A fictional proposal asks about six-month persistence, but its planned observation lasts two weeks. No later data access is confirmed. Clarify whether to change the research question or assess a longer design.

Role A: Research supervisor: explain the mismatch between outcome and observation period.

Role B: Researcher: propose a bounded short-term question without claiming long-term persistence.

Possible opening: Our two-week observation cannot directly establish the six-month outcome named in the question.

Success checks

- Distinguish short-term observation from long-term outcome.
- Do not assume later data access.
- Agree a question or design revision for review.

Add a complication: The researcher suggests labeling two-week attendance as six-month persistence.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

A pilot can test feasibility, not solve the whole field

Fictional grant review using the lesson case: a small pilot promises to solve a broad scientific problem.

01 • Grant reviewer: The draft promises to solve the broad problem. What can this small pilot actually establish?

02 • Principal investigator: It can examine feasibility of our proposed approach, but it cannot resolve the entire scientific question.

03 • Grant reviewer: Then the specific aims should distinguish what you will assess from the long-term significance.

04 • Principal investigator: Agreed. The broader motivation belongs in the rationale, not as a guaranteed result of the pilot.

05 • Grant reviewer: Do you already have evidence that recruitment and measurement will work as planned?

06 • Principal investigator: Not yet. Those are feasibility questions for the proposed study, not completed findings.

07 • Grant reviewer: Keep innovation separate too. A novel approach isn't automatically an effective one.

08 • Principal investigator: I'll describe what is new and what the pilot would test without claiming success in advance.

09 • Grant reviewer: That can still be persuasive if the aims are bounded and the limitations are explicit.

10 • Principal investigator: I'll revise the promise into a feasible assessment and retain the broader problem as motivation.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A promised recruitment rate has no pilot evidence

Fictional grant planning: a team proposes recruiting 30 participants in a month but has no recruitment-rate data or confirmed access arrangement.

01 • Research administrator: The grant says thirty participants will enroll in a month. What supports that feasibility claim?

02 • Principal investigator: It is a planning assumption. We don't have recruitment-rate evidence or a confirmed access arrangement yet.

03 • Research administrator: Then distinguish the proposed target from a guaranteed enrollment result in the specific aims.

04 • Principal investigator: Could the pilot itself assess recruitment feasibility rather than assume the target is already achievable?

05 • Research administrator: Yes, if the design and wording make that exploratory purpose clear and preserve required approvals.

06 • Principal investigator: I'll ask the recruitment partner about access without presenting their involvement as committed before confirmation.

07 • Research administrator: Good. A letter request isn't a completed partnership, and interest isn't verified recruitment capacity.

08 • Principal investigator: The significance section can explain why the population matters without exaggerating our access to it.

09 • Research administrator: Exactly. Reviewers should see the current evidence, the proposed work, and the uncertainties separately.

10 • Principal investigator: I'll revise the feasibility language and identify recruitment access as an unresolved condition in the plan.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Innovation does not guarantee superior performance

Fictional proposal review: a researcher calls a new measurement approach more accurate, although no comparison with the existing method has been completed.

01 • Grant-development officer: The draft calls the new method more accurate. Have you completed the comparison supporting that claim?

02 • Researcher: No. We have a new approach, but its accuracy relative to the existing method hasn't been evaluated.

03 • Grant-development officer: Then novelty supports an innovation description, not a completed superiority finding.

04 • Researcher: Could one specific aim compare agreement and error under defined conditions instead of promising better performance?

05 • Grant-development officer: That is more bounded. The proposed evaluation criteria still need to be justified in the methodology.

06 • Researcher: I'll describe the expected benefit as a hypothesis and distinguish it from what we've already observed.

07 • Grant-development officer: Please also explain the significance of learning that the method does not outperform the existing one.

08 • Researcher: That result could still inform method selection, though I shouldn't claim any outcome before the study.

09 • Grant-development officer: Exactly. A credible aim promises a relevant investigation, not the favorable answer reviewers might hope for.

10 • Researcher: I'll revise the proposal so innovation, feasibility, and untested performance expectations remain clearly separated.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Grant Proposals and Specific Aims

A grant draft promises to solve a broad scientific problem using a small pilot study.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Second round: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Model for scenario 1: The pilot can test feasibility and provide preliminary evidence. It cannot resolve the entire problem. I'll narrow the aim so the proposed work and the claim match.

Scenario 2 | The available equipment has not been reserved

A fictional grant budget assumes access to a shared instrument for four weeks. The facility has expressed interest but has not confirmed availability. Discuss feasibility wording and the information needed before claiming secured access.

Role A: Research administrator: identify the difference between interest and confirmed access.

Role B: Principal investigator: propose a conditional access request and honest grant wording.

Possible opening: The facility has expressed interest, but the four-week instrument allocation is not yet confirmed.

Success checks

- Keep proposed and confirmed resources separate.
- State the effect on feasibility without predicting rejection.
- Agree a specific facility confirmation request.

Add a complication: A collaborator asks to call the equipment reserved because the proposal deadline is close.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

The replication notes omit a protocol change

Fictional lab meeting using the lesson case: a new result differs from an earlier experiment, but the notes omit a protocol change.

01 • Lab lead: The results differ. Could you provide the protocol version and the change missing from these notes?

02 • Research associate: A preparation step changed, but the shared notes don't document its details yet.

03 • Lab lead: Please recover the actual record before our comparison review rather than reconstruct it from memory alone.

04 • Research associate: Should we describe the new run as a failed replication while that information remains incomplete?

05 • Lab lead: Not yet. We need to understand comparability and any protocol drift before assigning that interpretation.

06 • Research associate: I'll identify the changed step, available control records, and any information we cannot verify.

07 • Lab lead: Thank you. Also check whether the analysis assumption used for the earlier experiment remained the same.

08 • Research associate: I'll ask the analysis owner for that confirmation and keep observations separate from possible explanations.

09 • Lab lead: Can you bring the documented differences to the next lab meeting without promising a causal explanation?

10 • Research associate: Yes. I'll provide the records and gaps so the team can plan a meaningful comparison.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A control label is not a complete control definition

Fictional lab review: two datasets use the label control, but their treatment and collection conditions are not described together.

01 • Data analyst: Both files label a group control. Could you confirm whether the underlying conditions actually match?

02 • Lab researcher: I need to check the experiment records. The shared label alone doesn't describe the full setup.

03 • Data analyst: Please provide the treatment, timing, and relevant protocol version before I combine the data.

04 • Lab researcher: Would using the label as the grouping key count as an analysis assumption worth documenting?

05 • Data analyst: Yes. Assuming equivalent controls could change the interpretation, so it needs evidence rather than an implicit merge.

06 • Lab researcher: I'll request the original conditions from the experiment owners and note any differences they confirm.

07 • Data analyst: Thank you. Don't call those differences protocol drift until we know whether they were planned.

08 • Lab researcher: Understood. A deliberate design difference and an undocumented change need different explanations in the lab meeting.

09 • Data analyst: I'll hold the combined comparison until the control definitions are reviewed and the grouping decision is justified.

10 • Lab researcher: I'll bring the source records so that decision can be made with the actual conditions in view.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

An undocumented exclusion rule leaves comparability unresolved

Fictional analysis review: one run excluded incomplete records, while an earlier summary does not document its exclusion rule.

01 • Research supervisor: Your new analysis excludes incomplete records. Could you confirm how the earlier summary handled them?

02 • Research analyst: That exclusion rule isn't documented in the summary. I'll check the saved analysis and its notes.

03 • Research supervisor: Please do that before describing the difference as a replicated change in the underlying phenomenon.

04 • Research analyst: The result may reflect different analysis assumptions, but we haven't established that explanation yet.

05 • Research supervisor: Exactly. Request the original rule and preserve the current result rather than quietly forcing the totals to match.

06 • Research analyst: I'll compare record counts and exclusion decisions using the available versioned materials.

07 • Research supervisor: Can you bring the confirmed rules and any unrecoverable gaps to our next review?

08 • Research analyst: Yes. I won't invent an old rule if the saved material doesn't establish one.

09 • Research supervisor: Then we can distinguish a documented methodological difference from an unexplained result difference.

10 • Research analyst: I'll make that distinction explicit and ask the team to review any proposed reanalysis before proceeding.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Lab Meetings and Data Challenges

A result differs from an earlier experiment, but the lab notes omit a protocol change.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

Second round: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Model for scenario 1: Could we compare the protocol versions and recorded conditions? Please add the missing change to the record so the team can assess possible explanations for the difference.

Scenario 2 | The instrument setting is absent from the notes

A fictional replication uses an instrument whose setting was recorded for the new run but omitted from the earlier notes. The older setting is unknown. Request source information without assuming the two runs used the same value.

Role A: Lab coordinator: ask for the earlier instrument record and relevant protocol reference.

Role B: Research associate: identify available records and preserve unrecoverable gaps.

Possible opening: We have the new setting, but could you locate evidence for the setting used in the earlier run?

Success checks

- Do not backfill an unknown historical setting.
- Request a specific source record.
- Keep replication comparability unresolved until reviewed.

Add a complication: A colleague suggests copying the new value into the old notes to make them complete.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

A new question needs an approval-scope check

Fictional research-ethics discussion using the lesson case: a researcher wants secondary use of participant data before reviewing existing approval and consent materials.

01 • Researcher: Can we reuse the participant dataset for a new question since the original study was approved?

02 • Ethics coordinator: First clarify the new purpose and review the existing approval and informed-consent materials.

03 • Researcher: I haven't checked those documents. Does removing names automatically make the secondary use permissible?

04 • Ethics coordinator: No automatic conclusion follows here. The authorized ethics team needs the relevant scope and data details.

05 • Researcher: Should I ask the institutional review board, or IRB, whether an amendment or another route applies?

06 • Ethics coordinator: Use our institution's established review process and ask the responsible office which route is appropriate.

07 • Researcher: I'll describe the proposed question, requested fields, and intended access without starting the new analysis.

08 • Ethics coordinator: Good. Distinguish what the original human-subjects approval actually covers from what you hope it covers.

09 • Researcher: I'll retrieve the approved documents and mark any unclear consent provision for the office to assess.

10 • Ethics coordinator: Then the review can address the real proposed use rather than an assumption based on prior approval.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Public availability does not answer every ethics question

Fictional research planning: a team proposes studying publicly accessible forum posts; institutional review applicability and data handling have not been assessed.

01 • Graduate researcher: The forum posts are publicly accessible. Does that settle whether our study needs any ethics review?

02 • Research ethics adviser: Not by itself. Please clarify the question, collection approach, and planned handling for the responsible office.

03 • Graduate researcher: We haven't discussed whether quotations could make contributors identifiable in the final paper.

04 • Research ethics adviser: That is relevant context to raise, not a reason to make a blanket legal or ethical conclusion here.

05 • Graduate researcher: Should I begin collecting everything while we decide which details eventually matter to the study?

06 • Research ethics adviser: First establish the appropriate review route and scope. Don't assume public access authorizes every proposed research use.

07 • Graduate researcher: I'll prepare a bounded description and ask how human-subjects considerations apply to this particular proposal.

08 • Research ethics adviser: Good. Include the intended outputs so the reviewer can assess the actual sharing and identification questions.

09 • Graduate researcher: I'll keep collection and publication assumptions explicit rather than call the project automatically exempt.

10 • Research ethics adviser: Then the authorized office can give a case-specific determination through the established process.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Translated consent materials have unconfirmed review status

Fictional study preparation: translated participant information exists, but its review and approval status are unconfirmed; recruitment has not begun.

01 • Study coordinator: The translated consent materials are ready as files. Can recruitment begin with those versions?

02 • Ethics administrator: Could you confirm their review and approval status? File availability doesn't establish that they are authorized for use.

03 • Study coordinator: That status is unconfirmed. I assumed translation completion meant the materials were ready for participants.

04 • Ethics administrator: Please distinguish completed translation from the applicable review of informed-consent materials.

05 • Study coordinator: Should I compare the version identifiers with the approved study documents before contacting the review office?

06 • Ethics administrator: Yes. Provide the actual versions and ask which checks remain, rather than infer approval from similar titles.

07 • Study coordinator: I'll keep recruitment pending that confirmation and avoid promising a start date we don't yet control.

08 • Ethics administrator: Good. Also identify any proposed changes to the information content, not just the language label.

09 • Study coordinator: I'll bring the version record and open questions through the established ethics process.

10 • Ethics administrator: Then the responsible office can clarify the authorized materials without an unsupported assumption about readiness.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Research Ethics and Human Subjects

A researcher wants to reuse participant data for a new question. The existing approval and consent materials have not been reviewed.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Second round: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for scenario 1: Does the proposed use fall within the relevant approval and consent arrangements? Let's check with the appropriate ethics and data-governance processes before assuming reuse is permitted.

Scenario 2 | A collaborator asks for identifiable records

A fictional collaborator requests identifiable participant records for a new analysis. The original consent and collaboration-access arrangements have not been checked. No transfer has occurred. Clarify scope and the appropriate review route.

Role A: Principal investigator: describe the proposed use and identify the missing approval checks.

Role B: Ethics coordinator: ask about fields, purpose, access, and existing documents.

Possible opening: Before any transfer, we need to check whether the proposed access and purpose are covered by the relevant approvals and consent.

Success checks

- Do not equate seniority with approved access.
- Identify specific documents and proposed-use details.
- Keep transfer pending the responsible review.

Add a complication: The collaborator's seniority is offered as sufficient authorization.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Discuss contributions before deciding authorship

Separate fictional credit discussion: a collaborating researcher designed an interview guide and analyzed 20 transcripts, but has not drafted manuscript text. The researcher expected authorship; a draft lists an acknowledgment. Applicable criteria have not been reviewed.

01 • Project coordinator: The draft lists an acknowledgment. Could you explain your contribution and what credit you expected?

02 • Collaborating researcher: I designed the interview guide and analyzed twenty transcripts. I expected authorship, although I haven't drafted manuscript text.

03 • Project coordinator: So your contribution includes design and analysis, but not manuscript drafting. Have I captured that accurately?

04 • Collaborating researcher: Yes. Please distinguish analysis from data collection; those were different contributions.

05 • Project coordinator: Agreed. I'll record analysis separately. What concern do you want the group to address first?

06 • Collaborating researcher: Whether my contribution meets the applicable authorship criteria, rather than whether my job title sounds senior enough.

07 • Project coordinator: Authorship remains undecided. May I review the journal criteria and institutional guidance before we discuss eligibility together?

08 • Collaborating researcher: Yes. Please bring the criteria and include my account in that discussion, not just the acknowledgment proposal.

09 • Project coordinator: I'll own that review and circulate the unresolved eligibility question; today's summary doesn't approve either credit category.

10 • Collaborating researcher: Confirmed. The contribution summary is accurate, and I understand that authorship is still under review.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A software contributor was left out of the discussion

Separate fictional collaboration: a research software engineer built the analysis pipeline and tested missing-value handling but was absent from the credit discussion. The engineer expects authorship consideration and an accurate software contribution description. Eligibility is unassessed.

01 • Corresponding author: You weren't included in the credit discussion. What contribution and expectation did we miss?

02 • Research software engineer: I built the analysis pipeline and tested missing-value handling. I expected authorship consideration, not an automatic decision.

03 • Corresponding author: The draft calls it technical assistance. Does that describe your work accurately enough?

04 • Research software engineer: No. It hides the pipeline development and testing. Please name those activities when we assess my contribution.

05 • Corresponding author: Then the summary should say software development and missing-value testing, with authorship consideration requested. Is that accurate?

06 • Research software engineer: Yes. I also want to understand the applicable criteria before anyone treats software work as automatically excluded.

07 • Corresponding author: I'll review those criteria and the institution's advice route; corresponding-author coordination doesn't settle eligibility by itself.

08 • Research software engineer: Thank you. Can we keep acknowledgment and authorship distinct until that review and group discussion?

09 • Corresponding author: Agreed. I'll own the criteria review and bring your confirmed contribution summary; no credit decision is final.

10 • Research software engineer: That addresses my concern about being omitted while leaving the substantive authorship question open.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

An old author order is not current agreement

Separate fictional manuscript discussion: an early draft lists a collaborating statistician third. Since that draft, the statistician completed a sensitivity analysis and revised the results interpretation. The statistician requests an order review, not a guaranteed position. Current agreement and applicable ordering guidance are unconfirmed.

01 • Manuscript coordinator: The early draft lists you third. What changed in your contribution or expectations since then?

02 • Collaborating statistician: I completed the sensitivity analysis and revised the results interpretation. I want the order reviewed, not a guaranteed position.

03 • Manuscript coordinator: So you're asking us to consider those later contributions rather than automatically move you first?

04 • Collaborating statistician: Correct. Without everyone's updated contributions, I can't justify a specific order.

05 • Manuscript coordinator: I'll summarize your added analysis and interpretation work, with a request for collective review. Does that capture your position?

06 • Collaborating statistician: Yes. Please don't treat my earlier silence as agreement with the current author list.

07 • Manuscript coordinator: Understood. I'll review applicable ordering guidance and ask every collaborator to confirm their current contribution record.

08 • Collaborating statistician: Who will coordinate unresolved criteria questions before the list is represented as agreed for submission?

09 • Manuscript coordinator: I'll own that review and coordinate the appropriate advice request. Today's exchange confirms your account, not authorship or order.

10 • Collaborating statistician: Agreed. Keep the list provisional until the relevant criteria and collaborators' perspectives have been reviewed.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Authorship, Collaboration, and Credit

Collaborators disagree about authorship late in a project. Their contributions and expectations have not been discussed together.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You hold a relevant concern that has not been discussed. Raise it when invited and ask who will decide. Help the facilitator state one unresolved question accurately.

Second round: A participant interrupts or the meeting is running out of time. Protect a turn to speak and close with an accurate decision record.

Model for scenario 1: Could we document each contribution and review the applicable authorship criteria as a group? That will give us a clearer basis for the discussion than relying on assumptions about rank or effort.

Scenario 2 | An acknowledgment was added without consultation

A fictional draft thanks a collaborator by name, but the team has not discussed the description with that person or reviewed the applicable publication expectations. Discuss a consultation route before finalizing the acknowledgment.

Role A: Manuscript coordinator: identify the unconfirmed wording and invite the collaborator's perspective.

Role B: Corresponding author: clarify the review process without deciding consent or credit on their behalf.

Possible opening: The acknowledgment names the collaborator, but we haven't confirmed the wording with them or checked the relevant requirements.

Success checks

- Avoid assuming agreement from a positive label.
- Distinguish proposed wording from confirmed participation.
- Agree who will consult the collaborator and review requirements.

Add a complication: A colleague says being thanked is always harmless and needs no discussion.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

A claim extends beyond the study sample

Fictional peer-review discussion using the lesson case: a reviewer identifies an overgeneralized claim, and the authors agree the wording needs revision.

01 • Corresponding author: The reviewer says our claim goes beyond the sample. Do you agree we need to correct it?

02 • Coauthor: Yes. We described a general population although the study only supports a narrower sample-based statement.

03 • Corresponding author: How should we acknowledge that in the response letter without pretending the underlying data changed?

04 • Coauthor: We agree the original wording exceeded the study's scope and have narrowed the claim to the observed sample.

05 • Corresponding author: That is the response we can use after the revision is actually made, not before.

06 • Coauthor: Correct. For now, the revision is planned; we should confirm the text and locations before claiming completion.

07 • Corresponding author: Could you give a model replacement that preserves the result but removes the universal wording?

08 • Coauthor: In the sampled group, we observed the reported pattern; broader applicability remains untested.

09 • Corresponding author: I'll revise the manuscript and check the response against the actual changes during our major-revision review.

10 • Coauthor: Good. The correction should acknowledge the overstatement without claiming new evidence or dismissing the reviewer.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

The response says added, but the analysis is only proposed

Fictional revision meeting: a draft response says an additional analysis was added, although the team has only proposed it and has not run it.

01 • Revision coordinator: The response letter says we added an analysis, but it hasn't been run. We need to correct that.

02 • Coauthor: You're right. I wrote the planned response as though the work were already complete.

03 • Revision coordinator: Please give an accurate interim statement for our internal review, keeping the journal response unsubmitted.

04 • Coauthor: We propose an additional analysis to address this comment; its feasibility and results are not yet established.

05 • Revision coordinator: That separates intention from completion. We also shouldn't predict that the analysis will confirm our original claim.

06 • Coauthor: Agreed. Its outcome is unknown, and any final response must reflect what we actually do and find.

07 • Revision coordinator: If the analysis proves infeasible, we should explain the limitation rather than fabricate an addition.

08 • Coauthor: I'll discuss scope with the analysis owner and replace the premature completion wording now.

09 • Revision coordinator: Before submission, let's verify every change claim against the revised manuscript and available results.

10 • Coauthor: Yes. The final peer-review response will describe completed work accurately and identify any reasoned limitation.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Clarify an ambiguous comparison in the manuscript

Fictional peer review: a reviewer read better outcomes as a between-group comparison, but the analysis only describes change within one group.

01 • Lead author: The reviewer interpreted better outcomes as a comparison between groups. Our analysis only examines one group's change.

02 • Coauthor: Our wording invited that interpretation. We should acknowledge the ambiguity rather than blame the reviewer.

03 • Lead author: What replacement makes the analytical scope clear without claiming a causal effect?

04 • Coauthor: The observed outcome changed within the sampled group over the study period; no between-group effect was estimated.

05 • Lead author: That states what we measured and what we didn't. Should we also revisit the abstract?

06 • Coauthor: Yes. The same ambiguous phrase may appear elsewhere, but we should check rather than assume it does.

07 • Lead author: I'll review the claim locations and align the response letter with the actual revisions.

08 • Coauthor: Please distinguish the wording correction from any new analysis; we aren't adding a comparison dataset here.

09 • Lead author: The response will explain that we clarified the scope and retain the relevant limitation.

10 • Coauthor: Good. That directly addresses the reader's concern without overstating either the original analysis or the revision.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Peer Review and Revision Responses

A reviewer points out that a manuscript's claim goes beyond its sample. The authors agree that the wording needs revision.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are frustrated because an earlier message created an expectation. Explain that expectation. Ask your partner to distinguish the correction from anything still uncertain.

Second round: The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

Model for scenario 1: Thank you for identifying this limitation. We have narrowed the claim to the studied sample and added a discussion of generalizability. The response should point the reviewer to the revised passage.

Scenario 2 | A table heading suggests a causal effect

A fictional manuscript table is headed Program effect, but it reports an unadjusted association from observational data. The authors agree the heading is too strong. Discuss an accurate replacement and how to explain the correction to the reviewer.

Role A: Lead author: acknowledge the overstatement and propose association-based wording.

Role B: Coauthor: check that the response describes a wording correction, not new causal evidence.

Possible opening: The heading overstates the analysis; it should describe an observed association rather than a program effect.

Success checks

- Acknowledge the specific wording problem.
- Preserve the observational scope.
- Agree to verify the manuscript and response match before submission.

Add a complication: A collaborator wants to keep the stronger heading because it attracts attention.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Variable names need units and missing-value definitions

Fictional data handoff using the lesson case: a shared dataset has variable names but no units, missing-value descriptions, or collection dates.

01 • Research analyst: Could you provide the units, missing-value definitions, and collection dates for the shared dataset?

02 • Data curator: Those details aren't included in the current metadata. I'll check the original collection records.

03 • Research analyst: Please identify any information that cannot be recovered rather than infer it from plausible values.

04 • Data curator: Understood. A column called duration doesn't establish whether its values represent seconds, minutes, or another unit.

05 • Research analyst: Exactly. We need that context for reproducibility, meaning another researcher can understand and repeat the analysis appropriately.

06 • Data curator: I'll also document provenance, including which collection records and transformations produced this version.

07 • Research analyst: Can you bring the available documentation to our next analysis meeting and keep unresolved definitions explicit?

08 • Data curator: Yes. I'll link the metadata to the repository version rather than overwrite the description without a history.

09 • Research analyst: I'll hold interpretations that depend on unknown units or missing-value codes until they're clarified.

10 • Data curator: Thank you. The handoff will distinguish verified definitions from gaps instead of giving the data false precision.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Zero may mean a measurement or a missing code

Fictional dataset review: a variable contains zeros, but the data dictionary does not explain whether zero is a legitimate observation or missing-value code.

01 • Data analyst: Could you clarify whether zero is a measured value or a missing-data code in this variable?

02 • Research data manager: The dictionary doesn't specify it. I need to check the collection form and import documentation.

03 • Data analyst: Please do that before I calculate the mean, because treating missing codes as observations could change it.

04 • Research data manager: Would replacing every zero with missing be the safest temporary interpretation while we wait?

05 • Data analyst: Not necessarily. That could remove valid observations. We should preserve the raw values and flag the uncertainty.

06 • Research data manager: I'll request the coding definition from the collection owner and retain the source record for provenance.

07 • Data analyst: Please include the relevant dataset version so the answer doesn't accidentally apply to another release.

08 • Research data manager: Agreed. I'll update metadata only with verified information and identify any unresolved historical change.

09 • Data analyst: I'll defer that calculation and explain exactly which definition is blocking interpretation.

10 • Research data manager: Then the next researcher can trace the decision instead of inheriting an undocumented assumption.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A repository file changed after analysis

Fictional reproducibility review: a shared data file was replaced after analysis; the analyst recorded a version identifier, but the current filename is unchanged.

01 • Research coordinator: The repository filename is unchanged. Can we assume the current file is the one used for analysis?

02 • Data analyst: No. The file was replaced afterward, and I recorded a version identifier for the analyzed dataset.

03 • Research coordinator: Please provide that identifier and the corresponding code version so the review can locate the actual inputs.

04 • Data analyst: I'll provide them and request the earlier data version from the repository manager.

05 • Research coordinator: Does the replacement establish that our published result is wrong, or only that reproducibility needs checking?

06 • Data analyst: It establishes a version difference, not a wrong result. We need the actual inputs and change history.

07 • Research coordinator: Please preserve the provenance record and identify whether the older version remains accessible.

08 • Data analyst: I will. If it isn't available, I'll report that gap rather than claim a verified rerun.

09 • Research coordinator: Bring the records to our review before anyone substitutes the latest file silently.

10 • Data analyst: Agreed. The handoff will identify what was analyzed, what changed, and what can currently be reproduced.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Data Management and Reproducibility

A shared dataset has variable names but no description of units, missing values, or collection dates.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

Second round: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Model for scenario 1: Could you add a data dictionary covering units, missing-value codes, and collection dates? Those details will help another researcher interpret and reuse the data correctly.

Scenario 2 | Collection dates use two ambiguous formats

A fictional dataset includes dates such as 03/04/2025 from two source teams. Their date conventions are undocumented, and the source forms have not been checked. Request clarification before chronological analysis.

Role A: Research analyst: explain the ambiguity and preserve original values.

Role B: Data curator: identify source-team records needed to confirm interpretation.

Possible opening: This date could mean March fourth or April third; we need each source team's convention before ordering observations.

Success checks

- Do not infer dates from a preferred result.
- Request source-specific documentation.
- Preserve raw values and record the eventual verified transformation.

Add a complication: A colleague suggests choosing the interpretation that makes the trend smoother.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

A small study does not prove a general theory

Fictional conference Q&A using the lesson case: an audience researcher asks whether a small study proves a general theory.

01 • Audience researcher: Does your small study prove the general theory, or is that stronger than your evidence supports?

02 • Research presenter: It is stronger. Our observations are consistent with the theory under the studied conditions, not proof of its general validity.

03 • Audience researcher: What limitation matters most when interpreting the result beyond the people or conditions you sampled?

04 • Research presenter: The narrow sample limits generalizability. We haven't established that the same pattern holds in other populations.

05 • Audience researcher: Does that mean the result has no theoretical value unless you can test every possible population?

06 • Research presenter: No. It contributes bounded evidence and can help frame further tests without settling the whole theory.

07 • Audience researcher: What future work would address that boundary rather than merely repeat the strongest claim?

08 • Research presenter: A reviewed study across additional relevant populations could examine whether the observed pattern extends beyond this sample.

09 • Audience researcher: Thank you. So the current finding supports a narrower statement, with broader applicability still open.

10 • Research presenter: Exactly. That is the distinction I want the conference discussion to preserve.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A question asks for a result that was not measured

Fictional conference exchange: a presenter reports task completion, and an audience researcher asks whether participants also became more confident; confidence was not measured.

01 • Audience researcher: Participants completed more tasks in your report. Did they also become more confident?

02 • Research presenter: We didn't measure confidence, so I can't infer that outcome from task completion alone.

03 • Audience researcher: Would it be reasonable to describe confidence as the mechanism explaining the observed pattern?

04 • Research presenter: It could be a hypothesis for future work, but our study doesn't establish that mechanism.

05 • Audience researcher: Then the distinction is between the recorded behavior and an unmeasured psychological interpretation.

06 • Research presenter: Correct. We should preserve that limitation instead of adding an appealing explanation during the Q&A.

07 • Audience researcher: Could you propose a follow-up question without implying a particular measurement is already approved?

08 • Research presenter: We could ask how confidence and task completion relate under a reviewed design with appropriate measures.

09 • Audience researcher: That answers my question. The current presentation should stay with the outcome you actually observed.

10 • Research presenter: Thank you. I'll make that boundary explicit if I discuss possible mechanisms in the remaining session.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

An unfamiliar setting is outside the sample

Fictional conference Q&A: a study was conducted in one campus writing center, and a researcher asks whether the result applies to workplace training.

01 • Audience researcher: Your study was in a campus writing center. Would the same result apply to workplace training?

02 • Research presenter: We haven't tested that setting, so I can't claim the result transfers unchanged.

03 • Audience researcher: Which distinction should practitioners keep in mind without assuming workplaces are necessarily different in every respect?

04 • Research presenter: The study context is narrower than the proposed application. Relevant similarities and differences would need investigation.

05 • Audience researcher: So identifying a generalizability limitation doesn't prove the result will fail outside the campus.

06 • Research presenter: Exactly. It means transfer is unestablished, not that the opposite outcome is known.

07 • Audience researcher: Could a carefully reviewed workplace study become useful future work rather than an immediate practice recommendation?

08 • Research presenter: Yes. It could examine the relevant population, task, and context under an appropriate design.

09 • Audience researcher: I'll describe your finding as campus-specific evidence and the workplace question as still open.

10 • Research presenter: Thank you. That keeps the conference takeaway useful without extending the conclusion beyond the observed setting.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Academic Presentations and Conferences

An audience member asks whether a small study proves a general theory. The presenter needs a concise answer.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Second round: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Model for scenario 1: The study offers evidence relevant to the theory under these conditions. It does not establish the theory in every setting. A useful next step would test whether the finding holds in a broader sample.

Scenario 2 | The audience asks whether no difference proves equivalence

A fictional small study found no clear difference between two conditions. It was not designed as an equivalence study. An audience member asks whether the conditions are therefore interchangeable. Give a concise, bounded answer.

Role A: Research presenter: distinguish no clear detected difference from established equivalence.

Role B: Audience researcher: ask what further design or evidence would address equivalence.

Possible opening: We did not establish equivalence; this study found no clear difference under its particular design and conditions.

Success checks

- Do not convert an inconclusive comparison into equivalence.
- State the design boundary in plain language.
- Identify equivalence as a separate future research question.

Add a complication: The questioner asks for a simple yes that removes the limitation.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

US Department of Education: FERPA

<https://studentprivacy.ed.gov/ferpa>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the following prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Vocabulary and grammar prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has four practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

Each starter prompt uses B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-30. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Rehearse with an AI colleague

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Higher Education and Research English

Professional audience: faculty, postdoctoral researchers, graduate students, lab managers, research administrators, grant staff, ethics-board coordinators, and academic program leaders

Scope: All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Dialogue 01: Study design discussion

Original fictional setting: Researchers refine an overly broad question.

Professional roles: Principal investigator / Postdoctoral researcher

Published dialogue (reference script, not my own performance):

Principal investigator: Our question asks whether the program improves wellbeing. Which outcome and population do we mean?

Postdoctoral researcher: We should specify the target group, measurement instrument, and follow-up period.

Principal investigator: The available dataset may not cover the full period.

Postdoctoral researcher: Then either revise the feasible question or obtain suitable data; don't imply the design answers more than it can.

Principal investigator: I'll map the variables and missingness before we finalize the protocol.

Postdoctoral researcher: I'll review the design assumptions and proposed analysis with the team.

END REFERENCE**TASK: Interactive workplace role-play**

1. Use the supplied case or dialogue as the starting situation. Give a two-sentence briefing and offer two relevant professional roles for me to choose from. For a supplied dialogue, use its actual roles. Ask which role I want, then stop and wait. Do not write my replies.
2. After I choose, identify who you will play and the immediate communication goal. Play the other professional; where a meeting requires a third person, label each of your speakers clearly. Start with one natural workplace turn and wait for my reply. Keep most turns to one to three sentences and ask no more than one question at a time.
3. Let the exchange develop across six to ten learner turns, or end earlier if I type "feedback". Respond to what I actually say. Include a plausible clarification, disagreement or tradeoff without silently changing the starting facts. Mark any added constraint as a fictional second-round variation. Do not resolve approvals, evidence or commitments that remain uncertain.
4. Stay in role during the exchange. If my meaning is unclear, ask for clarification naturally. Give a hint only if I ask or cannot proceed. Do not deliver a model conversation in advance.
5. At the debrief, quote two of my phrases: one successful choice and one worth improving. Check factual accuracy, language, register and whether the next step was clear. Give up to three focused suggestions. Ask me to retry the weakest turn; wait. Only then offer an alternative wording and a harder replay.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level

Create more scenario dialogues

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

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Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

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Principal investigator: I'll map the variables and missingness before we finalize the protocol.

Postdoctoral researcher: I'll review the design assumptions and proposed analysis with the team.

END REFERENCE**TASK:** Extend the conversation library

1. Propose six distinct, common scenarios in this field beyond the supplied case or script. For each, name the setting, two or more professional roles, the communication problem and one useful terminology focus. Include routine coordination, clarification, a complication, disagreement, handoff and follow-up where relevant. Choose scenarios that fit this profession, rather than forcing unsuitable situations into it.
2. Ask me to choose one scenario, or request all six in sequence. Stop and wait. Do not write all the scripts before I choose.
3. For the selected scenario, write an original fictional dialogue of 12-18 substantial speaking turns between two or three professionals. Name each role, establish an actual work problem, and let the exchange progress through questions, clarification, competing constraints and a credible next step or explicitly unresolved issue. Use the occupation's natural nomenclature and register. Avoid an interview between a teacher and a learner, generic small talk, and inserting a glossary definition into every reply. Explain specialist terms outside the dialogue instead.
4. After the script, explain five useful expressions in context, identify two grammar or register choices and ask three questions about the speakers' reasoning. Withhold the answers until I attempt them. Add one role-switch challenge.
5. Before presenting a script, check names, numbers, chronology, roles and terminology for consistency. Label invented facts and acknowledge uncertain specialist usage. If I requested all six, deliver one complete script at a time and wait for "next". Make each scenario materially different.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level